

Queen Isabel's Roses

In the enchanted springs of Portugal, cobblestone towns sit among terracotta roofs, almond trees that blossom white as snow, and hills crowned with stars. Water is the magic here: every spring, fountain, and old stone well has its own quiet wonder. Enchanted maidens called the Mouras keep the springs sweet, a bright rooster crows only the truth, and a playful little goblin called the Trasgo tidies and teases when no one is looking. Here a hero wins not by being the strongest, but by being kind, asking the water gently, and never giving up on a friend. Even a big, fearsome-looking giant of the hills usually turns out to be lonelier than it is frightening.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.

★ *Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause often so everyone can puzzle, wonder, and try ideas. There are no wrong answers here, only new paths to follow.*

Before you begin

In the old riverside city of Coimbra, with its climbing stone streets and its castle on the hill, there lived a queen the people loved: good Queen Isabel. Her delight was to carry bread to those who had none, and she did it in secret, slipping out at dawn with a covered basket, because a kindness done for thanks, she said, is only half a kindness.

On the morning this story begins, the Queen was unwell and could not rise. She called you to her side and pressed her warm hands over yours. "I cannot make my round today," she said, "and there are hungry mouths who will go without. Will you carry the kindness in my place? Take bread to those who need it, and do it softly, the way I would, asking nothing back."

You promised that you would, and went down toward the waking city, the castle bells tolling gently behind you.

★ *What is your hero name? Which three magics will you carry: Bloom, Truth, Starlight, or Riversong?*

Stop 1 The Castle Kitchen

The castle kitchen was warm and golden, and its long table was heaped with rosca bread, ring upon ring of it, far more than the castle could eat before it went stale. By the hearth the old cook dozed, chin on chest, snoring softly.

Your task was a quiet one: to take only enough to share, no more than was fair, and to carry it away without waking the cook or drawing any eye, so the giving stayed as humble and secret as the Queen wished.

★ *How much do you take, and how do you carry it out without a sound? How do you keep the kindness from being noticed? What is your plan?*

When your basket held just enough, covered over with a clean cloth, you stepped out into the cool morning air without so much as a creak of the door. The cook slept on, none the wiser.

Stop 2 The Winding Streets

You carried the covered basket down into the maze of narrow streets, and there came the harder question: of all these doors, who needed the bread most? The Queen never gave at random; she gave where it mattered. So you looked closely, the way she would have. A chimney with no smoke rising. A doorstep where a thin cat waited in hope. A small, pale face at a window with no breakfast behind it.



Who do you think is in need this morning, and how can you tell? And how will you give the bread so that nobody is shamed by taking it?

When you left your loaves quietly at the right doors, with a soft word and never a fuss, the people who found them looked up in astonished gladness, and could not think whom to thank. The cold streets seemed to warm behind you as you went.

Stop 3 The Watchman's Gate

But to come and go from the castle you had to pass the gate, and at the gate stood the watchman: broad, stern, and sharp-eyed, with orders to keep. He stepped into your path and held up a hand. "Hold there. What is it you carry under that cloth?" he demanded. "The King has said plainly that the castle's bread is not to be given away at the gate, and I mean to see what you are about."

He was no villain, only a man doing his duty as he understood it, and he would not simply wave you through. He wanted the basket opened.



What do you say to the watchman? Will you tell him the truth of your errand? How can you help him see that carrying bread to the hungry is a good and gentle thing, worth his blessing rather than his blame?

When you answered him honestly, without fear and without a lie, and spoke of the Queen's kindness as the good thing it was, the hard set of his face began to ease. "Very well," he said, gentler now, almost curious. "Lift the cloth, then, and let me see for myself."

Stop 4 The Bread Becomes Roses

You drew a steadying breath and lifted the cloth, ready to show him everything and tell the whole truth, come what may. But under the cloth there was no bread at all.

Where the golden loaves had lain, the basket now brimmed with roses: fresh white and blushing pink, heavy with dew and scent, tumbling over the rim, though it was far from the season any rose should bloom. The kindness had become a small, bright miracle in your hands.



How does this make you feel, holding a basket of impossible roses? What do you say to the watchman now? Could your Bloom magic help the roses open fuller and brighter still?

The watchman looked, and looked again, and the sternness simply fell from him. There was nothing here to forbid, nothing to scold, only flowers out of season and a secret too gentle to punish. The Queen's quiet giving was safe, hidden inside a wonder, and the watchman, of all people, found he was smiling.

Roses All the Way Home

As you made your way back through Coimbra, the roses would not stay in the basket. They began to bloom along the tops of the walls, around the door frames, in the cracks of the old stone steps, until the whole climbing city wore them like a garland. People came out to

wonder, and finding themselves glad, began to share whatever they had with one another.

The watchman picked up an empty basket and asked, almost shyly, if he might help carry bread come the next dawn. And high in her room good Queen Isabel heard the laughter rising from the streets, and smiled to herself, for she knew that a kindness done softly had filled an entire city with flowers.

You did it together. You were honest when it would have been easier to hide, and you were kind when no one was watching, which is the kindest kind of all. Well done.

Queen Isabel's Roses: Rules for the Grown-Up

The Guide for the Grown-Up explains how the game works (the difficulty bands, the energy stars, helping, twists, all of it). This page has only what is special about this adventure. A failed roll is never a defeat; nobody loses.

Setting up

- Print the map, or sketch it, or lay it out with household objects: a Start, four stops, and a Goal on a winding path. Each player puts a small figure on the Start.
- Each player chooses three magics from the four in this world: Bloom, Truth, Starlight, and Riversong. Bloom shines in this story, but a mix works best.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). These are spent and refilled during play.
- Build the things that come up (the covered basket, the loaves, the roses) from household bits and bricks as you go. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

The surprise

Once at each stop the players may roll for a twist; read the matching line. The Guide explains how it works.

Roll	Surprise
1	A baker slips you a warm loaf and one free hint.
2	You find a coin in the cobbles: take back one energy star.
3	A kind neighbour points the way: the next challenge is Easy.
4	A waft of rose scent drifts by. All is well; carry on.
5	Queen Isabel's blessing lets you repeat one roll later, whenever you like.
6	A bell rings over the river and everyone feels brave for one turn.

How it ends

There is no villain in this story. The stern watchman is only doing his duty, and he is won over by honesty, not defeated. The climax is the gentle miracle the legend is famous for: the bread the children carry turns to roses, so a secret kindness is protected and nobody is scolded. Play it as a reward for honesty and quiet generosity, not a trick to fool anyone. The lesson is that kindness given softly, asking nothing back, is the kind that blooms. See the puzzles page for how to play each stop, and for the solutions.

Queen Isabel's Roses: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward good ideas and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Castle Kitchen (Easy)

The challenge. Take only a fair share of the rosca bread and carry it out quietly, without waking the dozing cook or making the giving showy.

Intended solutions. A gentle planning moment:

- **Truth** to judge honestly how much is fair to take and no more.
- **Riversong** to hush a creaky door or a sloshing jug so nobody stirs.
- A plain careful plan: counting out just enough loaves, padding the basket with the cloth so it makes no sound, tiptoeing past the hearth.

Fallback. If the children hesitate, have a kitchen cat lead them to the day-old loaves meant for sharing, settling the "how much is fair" question. Any quiet, fair plan works and tops up an energy star.

Make it simpler. For a younger child, just choosing two loaves and covering the basket with a cloth is the whole of it.

Stop 2: The Winding Streets (Normal)

The challenge. Work out, from small signs, who in the streets most needs the bread, and give it so nobody feels ashamed.

Solution. The clues are the cold details: a chimney with no smoke, a thin cat waiting, a pale child at a bare window. The players read these signs of need and leave bread quietly at those doors, with a kind word and no fuss. This is observation and empathy, not a magic, though

Starlight can light a dim doorway and **Bloom** can leave a small flower as a gentle, face-saving gift beside the loaf.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have a neighbour murmur which house has had no bread this week. Choosing kindly, even with a hint, is a full success and tops up an energy star.

Make it simpler. For a younger child, set out two doors, one warm and one cold, and ask only which one needs the bread.

Stop 3: The Watchman's Gate (Normal)

The challenge. The stern watchman blocks the gate and demands to see inside the covered basket. The players must win him over with honesty and kindness, not a lie and not a fight.

Intended solutions. A social, honest-heart moment:

- **Truth** is the natural fit: answer him plainly about the errand and the Queen's kindness, with nothing hidden.
- A warm, brave word: explain that the bread is for the hungry and ask for his blessing rather than his blame.
- **Bloom** or a shared loaf can thaw his mood and show good will.

Fallback. If the children freeze, have the watchman's own stomach rumble, prompting a child to offer him a loaf, which softens him at once. Any honest, gentle answer makes him relent and ask to see the basket.

Make it simpler. For a younger child, simply telling the watchman "it is bread for people who are hungry" is enough to win him over.

Stop 4: The Bread Becomes Roses (Easy)

The challenge. Lift the cloth and show the watchman the truth, trusting that kindness done honestly will come right. There is no roll to fail; the miracle rewards the children's honesty.

Intended solution. Have the players bravely lift the cloth to reveal the bread has become roses. **Bloom** fits beautifully here, helping the roses open fuller, but the wonder happens for any child who chose honesty at the gate. Let them enjoy the watchman's astonishment.

Fallback. If a child is anxious about opening the basket, let the roses' scent escape first, hinting that something lovely waits inside, so lifting the cloth feels safe. The success is guaranteed.

Make it simpler. For a younger child, simply lifting the cloth and discovering the roses together is the whole of it.

Roses All the Way Home (no roll)

This is the resolution, not a puzzle, so there is no band and no roll. Roses bloom through Coimbra, neighbours share what they have, and the won-over watchman offers to help carry bread next dawn. Let the children feel the whole city soften and Queen Isabel's quiet smile. They won by being honest and generous when no one was watching, which is the only way anyone wins among the Enchanted Springs.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.